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MethodHub — FAQ for non-technical staff

A plain-language guide to what MethodHub is, how it is built, how it protects user data, and what is asked of the EEA. Every term of jargon unpacked as it first appears. No prior software knowledge assumed.

Code stewards · CCE5 (EEA unit)

Hosting target · EEA infrastructure, EU region

Primary user · the ESABCC Secretariat

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Audience. Secretariat colleagues, EEA managers, peer EEA units evaluating the pattern, DPO, and anyone doing an internal review. If you are a developer, skip this and read the main docs site.

Part 1 — The big picture

1. What is MethodHub, in one paragraph?

MethodHub is an **internal research workspace** designed for the Secretariat of the **European Scientific Advisory Board on Climate Change (ESABCC)**. Once properly deployed and adopted, the intent is that it becomes part of the Secretariat's daily toolkit: bringing into one place the activities that today are spread across Word documents, shared drives, EndNote libraries, and a dozen public websites — managing references, exploring climate data and scenarios, following policy news, navigating EU climate laws, and doing qualitative coding of policy text. Think of it as "Google Docs + EndNote + a climate-data browser + a policy tracker, but private, EU-hosted, and purpose-built for the Secretariat". It is currently a developed prototype; roll-out to users is the next step after the EEA hosting conversation lands.

2. Is it a public website?

No. **MethodHub is an internal tool.** The intended audience is the ESABCC Secretariat: once deployed, members will use it to manage references, explore data, follow news, and analyse policy text. The source code lives in a public repository on GitHub (see Q10), but the running application is intended to live on EEA infrastructure, behind EU Login, so nothing the Secretariat writes in MethodHub leaves that environment.

3. Does anything in MethodHub constitute official Board advice?

No. MethodHub is designed as a **working tool**, not a publication channel. Board advice comes out through the Board's formal publications. MethodHub is intended to help the Secretariat prepare that advice faster and more transparently, but any outputs produced inside it are working drafts until the Board signs off through its normal process.

4. What are "the five modules"?

MethodHub v1.0 ships with five focused areas:

1. **Reference Manager** — a searchable literature library with one-click DOI lookup and a Word add-in for inline citations.

2. **Data & Scenarios** — Eurostat indicators alongside the IPCC and IIASA scenario databases, all in one chart.
3. **Secretariat News** — a curated climate-policy news feed, an automated 24-hour EU briefing, and an AI-written narrative summary.
4. **EU Policy Navigator** — a network map of EU climate laws with article-level text and annotation.
5. **Content Analysis** — MAXQDA-style qualitative coding of policy texts and references (MAXQDA is a commercial coding tool; this is the in-browser equivalent).

Everything else (energy-system modelling, media monitoring, Brussels Bulletin, etc.) is parked in a `beta/` folder in the repo. It exists, it works, but it is deliberately not shipped in v1.0 so the scope stays reviewable.

5. Who built it, who will keep building it?

CCE5. A small unit inside the EEA. The intent is that, after the app is handed over for hosting, **CCE5 remains the code owner** — features, fixes, migrations, and data pipelines continue to ship from the CCE5 team through the same GitHub repository. That split (CCE5 ships code, a hosting partner runs the service) mirrors the pattern the EEA already uses for its Plone stack at github.com/eea — code in the open, services in the EU region. Other arrangements are of course possible; this is the one the codebase is set up for today.

Part 2 — The tech stack in plain English

Every piece of jargon you'll hear in the docs, explained in one or two paragraphs. Skip anything you don't need.

6. What is Next.js, and why did you pick it?

Next.js is a framework for building modern web applications. A "framework" is a prepackaged skeleton that handles the boring plumbing of a website — page routing, forms, server-side rendering, asset optimisation — so that the team can focus on the Secretariat's actual features instead of reinventing that plumbing.

Why we picked it.

- It's built on **React**, today's most widely used web-UI toolkit, so finding help and future developers is easy.
- It produces a **single self-contained application** ("standalone output") that runs as one process. No exotic dependencies.
- It supports both static pages and dynamic server code in the same project, so every module in MethodHub — a chart, a data API, a search page — lives in the same codebase.

Alternatives we considered — Django (Python), Rails (Ruby), SvelteKit — each have merits, but Next.js has the largest community, the smoothest container-deploy story, and direct compatibility with the Microsoft / Copilot integrations we wanted open as an option.

7. What is Docker / a container?

Imagine zipping up an entire computer — the operating system, your program, all its libraries, all its configuration — into one file. A **container** is that zip file. **Docker** is the most common way to build and run containers.

Why it matters for MethodHub.

- The app runs the same on a developer's laptop, on a test server, and on EEA's production infrastructure — because it's always the same zipped "computer-in-a-file".
- EEA IT doesn't have to install Node.js, Python, particular library versions, etc. They run the container; everything else is inside it.
- Any platform that can run OCI containers (Podman, OpenShift, Nomad, a plain VM) can run MethodHub. EEA picks whatever they already use.

The MethodHub container is about **180 MB** — roughly the size of a single large video file. It holds the full application.

8. What is Postgres (PostgreSQL)?

PostgreSQL (often just "Postgres") is a **database**. A database is where the app stores everything users create — references they add, annotations they write, codings they apply, and so on. Postgres is

free, open-source, and the default choice for almost every serious European public-sector project; it is not owned by a single company.

Why Postgres, specifically.

- Mature, well-documented, used by many EEA systems already.
- Supports "row-level security" (RLS) — the ability to say "user A can only see user A's annotations" inside the database itself, so a bug in the application can't accidentally leak data.
- Plays nicely with tools EEA IT already operates (`pg_dump` , `pg_restore` , `pgBouncer` , standard monitoring).

MethodHub talks to Postgres through a thin layer called **Supabase** during development (see Q12), and directly in production.

9. What is Supabase?

Supabase is an open-source product that bundles Postgres with four conveniences — authentication, file storage, realtime updates, and a REST/GraphQL layer. You can use it as a hosted service (like Google's, but EU-region), or run it yourself on your own servers.

In MethodHub we use Supabase **during iteration** because it lets a small team spin up a working database in minutes. For **production on EEA infrastructure**, we swap it out for a plain Postgres + normal file storage + OIDC login — no change to the application code, just one-line switches in a config file (`DB_PROVIDER` , `AUTH_PROVIDER` , `STORAGE_PROVIDER`).

10. What is GitHub? What is a "repository"?

GitHub is a website that stores code and keeps a complete history of every change to that code. A **repository** (or "repo") is one project's folder on GitHub. MethodHub's repo lives at `github.com/SebastianFra/MethodHub` — today under a personal account, intended to move under an ESABCC or EEA GitHub organisation later (see Q18).

The point of using GitHub, even for an internal tool:

- **Reviewable history.** Every change is recorded and attributed, so six months from now anyone can ask "why did we do X?" and get a traceable answer.
- **Cheap collaboration.** Two CCE5 colleagues can work on different modules without stepping on each other.
- **Standard practice.** The EEA already uses GitHub (`github.com/eea`) for its Plone stack, so there is no policy conflict.

11. What is OIDC / EU Login?

OIDC (OpenID Connect) is the standard technology behind "Sign in with Microsoft / Google / your work account". **EU Login** is the European Commission's OIDC service used across EU institutions for staff sign-in. **Azure AD** (now Microsoft Entra ID) is Microsoft's equivalent for organisations.

In MethodHub, once the app is on EEA infrastructure, signing in is done through OIDC. No MethodHub-specific username/password is created — your existing EU staff identity is what logs you in. When you leave, EU Login stops working and so does your MethodHub access, automatically.

12. What is the "AI layer" — Azure OpenAI vs M365 Copilot?

MethodHub uses AI for a few specific things: summarising the daily news briefing, suggesting codes in Content Analysis, and producing abstracts. Two realistic paths exist; we support both behind a single configuration switch.

Path A — Azure OpenAI EU. A Microsoft-run service that hosts Large Language Models (LLMs, the technology behind ChatGPT) in **EU data centres**. EEA would pay per amount of text processed ("per token"). This is how most organisations consume AI today.

Path B — Microsoft 365 Copilot licences. If EEA already pays for per-user Microsoft 365 Copilot licences (the "AI assistant inside Word, Teams, Outlook"), MethodHub can route every AI call through **each user's own Copilot seat** via Microsoft Graph (Microsoft's standard API). The advantages:

- No separate AI subscription — we reuse what EEA already buys.
- No service API key for MethodHub to hold — every call is authorised by the signed-in user's own account.
- Microsoft's tenant-level data-loss-prevention policies apply automatically.

The main caveat: Path B only works for AI calls a user triggers. Background jobs (the overnight news summariser) have no signed-in user and fall back to Path A.

13. What is Microsoft Graph?

Microsoft Graph is the name of Microsoft's unified REST API for everything in a Microsoft 365 tenant — your mailbox, your OneDrive, Teams messages, and more recently Copilot. Using Graph from MethodHub means we **do not need a separate Copilot subscription**; we use the signed-in user's existing entitlement.

14. What is StaticCrypt? Why is the docs site password-protected?

StaticCrypt is a small open-source tool that encrypts every page of a static website with a password and wraps it in a password prompt. It runs at build time. The browser downloads the encrypted bundle and decrypts it locally after the user enters the correct passphrase.

Why we use it for the docs site: it's the cheapest way to keep the long-form documentation out of public search engines without upgrading the GitHub plan. It's **not a replacement for real single-sign-on** — anyone with the passphrase can read. We rotate it when it leaks. The long-term plan is to serve the docs from inside the MethodHub app under OIDC.

15. What is MkDocs?

MkDocs is a tool that turns a folder of Markdown files into a polished documentation website. The **MkDocs Material** theme gives it the clean, searchable, ESABCC-styled look you see at the docs URL.

16. What does "standalone output" mean?

Next.js, by default, produces a website that needs a Next.js-aware runtime to run. Setting `output: 'standalone'` in the config tells Next.js to instead bake **everything** (runtime, libraries, app code) into a single folder that can be launched with `node server.js` — no special platform required. This is what lets MethodHub run as a plain Docker container on any EEA host.

17. What does "RLS" mean? (Row-level security)

"Row-level security" is a Postgres feature that lets you define, in the database itself, who is allowed to read or write each specific row. MethodHub uses RLS so that a user's annotations and codings are visible only to them (and, where appropriate, to colleagues they share a workspace with). A bug in the application code cannot override RLS — the database refuses the query.

Part 3 — Hosting options we've prepared

Framing note. Nothing in this section is a prescription. Everything below is a **starting point** — a shape that the codebase is already wired for, so it plugs in cleanly. If any hosting partner (EEA IT or someone else) prefers a different operational model, substituting it is a configuration change, not a code change.

18. What does a reasonable hosting setup look like?

As a baseline we have in mind, three pieces would cover it:

1. **A place to run one container.** Anything that runs standard OCI containers — Podman, OpenShift, Nomad, or a plain virtual machine — works. The container is ~180 MB and needs about as much memory as a small web app (512 MB to 1 GB is plenty).
2. **A Postgres 14+ database** (or any compatible equivalent). The hosting partner manages it as they would any other Postgres instance — backups, patching, restore. MethodHub just needs a connection URL and credentials.
3. **A reverse proxy with a TLS certificate** on an EEA-owned domain. Most EEA services already sit behind one (nginx or HAProxy); MethodHub fits into the same pattern.

Each of these choices can be swapped for whatever the hosting partner already prefers — container orchestrator, database engine variant, TLS terminator — via environment-variable switches rather than code changes.

19. What extensions does the codebase already support?

Three optional extensions are wired in. If any of them are provided, MethodHub picks them up via a one-line config switch; if not, it falls back to a sensible default.

- **OIDC sign-in** (EU Login / Azure AD are the obvious fits, but any OIDC-compliant identity provider works). Without this, MethodHub uses development-time authentication.
- **S3-compatible object storage** (EEA MinIO would fit naturally, but any S3-compatible service does). Without this, PDFs sit in the database itself.
- **An AI provider** — two paths are prepared: Azure OpenAI EU, or per-user M365 Copilot via Microsoft Graph (Q12). Without either, MethodHub's AI features are disabled; everything else still works.

The hosting partner is welcome to propose entirely different choices (a different identity provider, a different object store, a different LLM provider); the codebase is deliberately structured so those substitutions are straightforward.

20. What the codebase doesn't assume of the hosting partner

Just for clarity on what is *not* implied:

- **No new software on the host** beyond whatever container runtime is already in use. Node.js, Python, libraries — all inside the container.

- **No access** to Active Directory trees, shared drives, or build servers beyond what the hosting partner already uses.
- **No specific monitoring stack.** MethodHub exports standard JSON logs and a `GET /api/health` endpoint; any monitoring already in place can plug in.
- **No ongoing development work.** The intent is that CCE5 keeps owning the code and the hosting partner operates the service, but this is a proposal — other arrangements are possible.

21. How long would the handoff take?

Based on the dry-runs we can do against a staging clone, an **afternoon** is realistic for a staging environment and a **working day** for production. The scripts that verify a clean cutover are in the repo (`scripts/migrate-to-postgres/`) and check row-for-row that a Supabase database and a self-hosted Postgres are equivalent. This is the path the codebase is prepared for; other handoff patterns are of course workable too.

22. What happens after handoff if a bug fix or a new feature is needed?

The intended flow: CCE5 ships a change through the GitHub repository (pull request → review → merge to `main` → new Docker image tag). The hosting partner pulls the new image tag into the running environment on their own cadence — for example, weekly for minor updates, immediately for security fixes. Nothing on the CCE5 side changes after handoff. This is one pattern that works well and that the codebase supports; nothing about it is rigid.

Part 4 — Data, privacy, GDPR

23. Where does user-entered data live?

Wherever the hosting partner stands up Postgres. The design keeps everything user-entered — annotations, codings, reference library entries, custom tags — in that one database. The pattern we have in mind is an EEA-managed Postgres in the EU region, but any compatible Postgres works. Nothing user-entered is written back to GitHub or to any third-party cloud.

24. What personal data does MethodHub collect?

The minimum needed to know who wrote what. Concretely:

- **Identity** — the email and display name returned by EU Login when a user first signs in. No password is stored; EU Login handles authentication.
- **Content a user creates** — references, annotations, codings, comments, and the timestamps when they were created or edited.
- **Operational logs** — the request timestamps, latency and response codes for AI calls (without prompt text) so the hosting partner can monitor the service. No body content, no prompt content.

That's it. No analytics beacons, no third-party trackers, no cookies beyond the session cookie.

25. How is GDPR handled in the code?

Not as an afterthought. Three things live next to the schema:

- **Row-level security (Q17)** — the database enforces that a user can only see their own annotations / codings / references.
- **Retention windows** — values stored in Postgres configuration so EEA's Data Protection Officer can tune them without a code change. News articles are purged after 365 days by default; AI call audit after 90 days; admin audit log after 3 years.
- **Right to erasure (Article 17)** — a database function called `erase_user()` cascades through every row a user has authored, deletes the owned content, and anonymises their identity on collaborative content. The user can trigger it from their profile page; the DPO can trigger it directly.

See `docs/GDPR.md` in the docs site for the full inventory and for the DPO sign-off checklist.

26. Is user-entered text sent to an AI provider?

Only when a user explicitly asks for an AI action, and only the text they chose. The app never sends prompts in the background without a user-initiated call, unless explicitly enabled (for example, the daily news summariser, which processes *public* news articles, not user content). The

`AUTO_LLM_SUMMARIZATION_ENABLED` switch is **off by default** for user-content pathways.

Where the prompt goes:

- **Path A — Azure OpenAI EU.** Microsoft's EU data centres. Microsoft's published commitments apply (no training on customer data, EU Data Boundary).
- **Path B — M365 Copilot via Graph.** Processed inside the organisation's own M365 tenant under whatever DLP and sensitivity- label policies that tenant enforces. For an EEA tenant this tends to be stronger than Path A operationally.

27. Does the news feed pull content from outside the EU?

Yes, but only **public** RSS feeds (European Commission, Parliament, Carbon Brief, EurActiv, Climate Home News, etc.). MethodHub downloads their headlines and summaries the same way a browser or any aggregator would. No user data goes *out* in the reverse direction.

28. Who can see what?

Three permission levels today:

- **Anonymous** — not signed in. Sees nothing.
- **Signed-in user** — can create and edit their own content, read what other users have marked as shared.
- **Admin** — a small, named list kept in a database configuration value. Admin actions are logged to `admin_audit_log`.

There is no "super-admin" escape hatch. The only path to see another user's private content is either through explicit sharing by that user, or through the DPO's authorised use of the erasure or export functions.

Part 5 — Cost, maintenance, vendor lock-in

29. What would MethodHub cost to run?

On the baseline setup we have in mind, the running-cost line items would be:

- **One container host.** Marginal if the hosting partner already runs a container platform — the app is small and sits alongside whatever else they operate.
- **One Postgres database.** Also marginal if shared Postgres capacity is already available.
- **Optional AI costs.** Under Path A (Azure OpenAI EU), per-token billing applies. Under Path B (per-user M365 Copilot), the cost is absorbed into existing Copilot seats and there is no extra subscription for AI.

Notably absent from the design: **no SaaS subscription, no per-user licence fee, no Vercel bill.** The codebase itself is open-source and costs nothing. Different hosting choices are of course possible and would have their own cost profile.

30. What happens if CCE5 is unavailable?

Two backstops.

- The source is in a public GitHub repository with full documentation (architecture, deployment, data layer, operational scripts). Any competent development team — another EEA unit, a contractor, a successor to CCE5 — can pick it up.
- The running app is a plain container against a plain Postgres. The hosting partner can keep the service running indefinitely even if no new features ship.

31. What stops MethodHub from becoming a maintenance burden?

Three deliberate choices in the architecture:

- **Small scope.** Five modules locked; everything else parked in `beta/`. The production surface is bounded.
- **Standard parts.** Every technology choice (Next.js, Postgres, Docker, OIDC) is mainstream. Finding people who know them is easy and stays easy.
- **No bespoke infrastructure.** The app is a standard container. Migrating it between hosts — even between cloud providers — is a few hours of work, not a project.

32. Are we locked into Microsoft / Anthropic / any vendor?

No, by design. A single configuration switch (`LLM_PROVIDER`) lets MethodHub use Azure OpenAI, Anthropic, Microsoft 365 Copilot, Google Gemini, or nothing. Switching is a one-line change in a config file, not a code rewrite. Same for the database (`DB_PROVIDER` between Supabase and plain Postgres), the storage (`STORAGE_PROVIDER` between Supabase and S3-compatible) and the auth provider (`AUTH_PROVIDER` between Supabase Auth and OIDC).

33. What is "the blueprint"?

MethodHub is designed so it can double as a **reference implementation** for other EEA units that might want a similar internal workspace — reference management, data exploration, document coordination. Forking the repository, changing the seed data, and re-skinning the branding should be a matter of days, not quarters. The docs site has a dedicated "Blueprint for EEA units" section with the fork recipe. Whether any other unit ever picks this up is obviously their call; the codebase is ready for it if the conversation comes up.

Part 6 — Glossary

A one-line definition for every term of jargon used in this FAQ or in the rest of the documentation. Alphabetical.

- **API.** A programmatic interface one program uses to talk to another, usually over HTTPS. MethodHub's own API is the set of server endpoints under `/api/...`.
- **Azure AD / Entra ID.** Microsoft's identity service for organisations; handles sign-in and token issuance. OIDC-compliant.
- **Azure OpenAI.** Microsoft's managed hosting of OpenAI's LLMs, runnable in an EU region.
- **CCE5.** The EEA unit that builds and maintains MethodHub's code.
- **CELEX.** EUR-Lex's unique identifier for an EU legal act (for example, `32023R0857`).
- **Container.** See Q7. A self-contained bundle of an application and its dependencies that runs identically on any host.
- **Crossref.** A non-profit consortium that maintains a free API for resolving DOIs into bibliographic metadata.
- **CSL-JSON.** A standard JSON shape for bibliographic data, used by Zotero and by MethodHub's Word add-in.
- **Docker.** The most common tool for building and running containers.
- **DOI.** Digital Object Identifier — the stable reference used by academic publishers (`10.1038/...`).
- **EEA.** European Environment Agency — the EU agency that hosts the ESABCC Secretariat.
- **ESABCC.** European Scientific Advisory Board on Climate Change — the independent scientific body MethodHub serves.
- **EU Data Boundary.** Microsoft's commitment that, for EU-tenant customers, specified services process data only in the EU region.
- **EU Login.** The European Commission's OIDC single-sign-on used across EU institutions.
- **EUR-Lex.** The EU's official legal-text repository.
- **GDPR.** General Data Protection Regulation — the EU data- protection law that governs how MethodHub handles personal data.
- **GitHub.** A code-hosting service and the current home of MethodHub's source code.
- **LLM.** Large Language Model — the AI technology behind ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, Gemini.
- **MkDocs.** The tool that renders the Markdown in `docs/` into the searchable password-gated documentation website.
- **OCI.** Open Container Initiative — the vendor-neutral standard that Docker, Podman and friends all implement.
- **OIDC.** OpenID Connect — the standard for delegated sign-in; EU Login is an OIDC provider.
- **Next.js.** See Q6. The web framework MethodHub is built on.
- **Postgres / PostgreSQL.** See Q8. The database MethodHub uses.
- **RLS.** Row-level security. See Q17.
- **RSS.** An older standard for machine-readable news feeds, still supported by most publishers.

- **StaticCrypt.** See Q14. The tool that encrypts the docs site behind a password.
- **Supabase.** See Q9. Postgres plus conveniences, used during iteration.
- **Word add-in.** A small Microsoft Office extension that puts MethodHub's reference library inside Microsoft Word.